



Neechalkaran's automated bot has created over 22,500 Wikipedia articles, including data from Tamil Nadu government, all for his love of Tamil

Jayesh Shinde | jayesh@digit.in

Wikipedia has become a necessary touchpoint for online research, whether you like it or not – it's the fourth most visited online destination in the world, behind only Facebook, YouTube and Google. But where Google has Sundar Pichai, Facebook is Mark Zuckerberg, and other big tech platforms have familiar faces, Wikipedia's brand isn't personified by any one individual. On the contrary, Wikipedia's ubiquity is built on the shoulders of anonymous community contributors like Neechalkaran, who's carving a Tamil wiki niche unlike any other.

Originally from Madurai, Tamil Nadu, Neechalkaran started reading and writing in Tamil after he started working for Infosys, which involved relocating to Pune, Maharashtra. "Since I was far away from my native Tamil community, I kept in touch with Tamil by reading online Tamil blogs at the time, and eventually started my own Tamil blog on Blogspot," Neechalkaran explained, who even started writing Tamil poetry.

FOR THE LOVE OF TAMIL

Soon he discovered the Tamil Wikipedia page and started contributing articles there in his free time, registering on it in 2010. A year or two down the line, he discovered a problem. "People who read my articles on Tamil Wikipedia and even my own blog started commenting that my articles had lots of grammatical errors," admitted Neechalkaran wholeheartedly. But far from getting disheartened



Neechalkaran

or dejected, Neechal took it as a challenge to solve through tech.

"That was truly the turning point for me, when I devoted some time to learning Tamil grammar and built Naavi, a Tamil spell checker specifically related to Sandhi rule," Neechal recalled. Tamil readers from all around the world, including a few professors, appreciated Neechalkaran's Tamil spell checker tool, he claimed. This only boosted his confidence further, making him learn not only Javascript but also Python and C#, and focusing on solving some of the problems faced by the Tamil Wikipedia's volunteers. At the time, Tamil Wikipedia contributors were able to write articles, but they found some difficulty in doing housekeeping activities, like editing some values in multiple pages or bulk editing, a lot of small tasks that needed to be automated, according to Neechalkaran.

It was in 2015-16 when the Tamil Nadu government was looking to digitize and release some village-level data, where the Tamil Wikipedia got involved in the project, Neechalkaran told. "The Tamil Wikipedia community had several discussions with